Amy's Answering Machine: Messages from Mom

By Amy Borkowsky

(Note: Amy's mom peppers her words with Jewish phrases – See glossary at the end of this selection)

INTRODUCTION

Does your mother call you in a panic whenever there's a storm warning for your area? Does she act as though it's her duty to alert you to every health story on the news? Have you ever been briefly out of touch with your mother only to find she's phoned everyone short of the National Guard to track you down – Or, just maybe, are you that mother? Take comfort in knowing you're not alone! This is

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AMY: **(Pg 14)** I have a radio that gives weather forecasts every few minutes, and a TV with a channel devoted entirely to the weather. So why does my mother always feel compelled to call me up with a weather report?

AMY'S MOM: *(BEEP)* Amila?

AMY: **(Pg 9)** You may wonder why my mother calls me "Amila" (pronounced AY-muh-luh) when my name is actually Amy. The answer is that, as a classic Jewish mother, my mom follows the tradition of adding an "ila" to my name as a term of endearment. And here and there, my mother uses some other Yiddish phrases.

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AMY'S MOM: **(Pg 14-15)** Amila? I hope you're on your way home. I just heard on the weather, there's a big storm headed for New York and they're expecting four to six inches in the city, with accumulations of up to a foot in the outlying areas. So if I were you. I wouldn't go ***shlepping*** to any outlying areas. On the weather map, all over New York, they had snowflakes the size of bagels. So if you have to go out, make sure you bundle up. And wrap a scarf around your face to protect it, 'cause y'know, there was that man who climbed Mount Everest and lost his entire nose. Okay, honey? I love you. Bye.

AMY: Somehow I just don't see anywhere I would ***shlep*** to as being quite parallel to climbing Mt. Everest.

NEWS REPORTER: Our guest today is Amila Borkowsky, the first woman ever to reach the summit of Macy's department store. So, Amila, what was it like up there?

AMY: Words just can't describe it. The view of Linens and Housewares was breathtaking.

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NEWS REPORTER: Now the question everyone want to know is, what did you buy?

AMY: Nothing. By the time I got there, they didn't have the one item I really needed.

NEWS REPORTER: What was that?

AMY: A new nose!

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AMY'S MOM: **(Pg 29-30)** *(BEEP)* Amila? I don't think you went to bed yet, but maybe you're in the tub. I wanted to know if you happened to catch the story on the new squirting scam. Apparently, the way it works is, you'll be walking along the street, and some guy or maybe a woman will squirt you from behind with a bottle of ketchup. Then someone else who's in cahoots with that person will say, "Excuse me, Miss, but there's some ketchup on your sweater." And then, just as you go to wipe it, they grab your bag and that's the end of that. So if somebody tries to point out any ketchup on you, you can just say something like, "I'm well aware of the ketchup – in fact it matches my pants that have a big blob of relish." Then as they're looking down at your pants, you can make a quick qetaway. All right, I hope

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you're doing good, and I'll talk to you tomorrow. Bye-bye.

AMY: In a world where innocent people are being randomly attacked with guns, knives, and AIDS-filled syringes, I find it hard to lose even a millisecond of sleep worrying that someone's going to come after me with a bottle of ketchup.

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AMY'S MOM: **(Pg 57)** *(BEEP)* Hi, Amila. It's me. Y'know the red terry robe you wore when I came to visit – it's like a ruby red with a belt? Do you still wear that or did you throw it out? I just wanna tell you that if you take out the garbage or run to the mailbox, you may wanna put on something else, because my friend Eileen's grandson said that red is a gang color. Okay, Sweetie-pie? Talk to you later.

AMY: Now what are the odds that two violent street gangs are going to decide to have it out on the twelfth floor of a Murry Hill doorman building, at the exact moment that I'm carrying out a bag of trash, totally oblivious to the Crips and the Bloods lining the hallway? They'll be yelling . . .

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GANG MEMBER: Don't go after Julio – he's not the leader!

GANG MEMBER 2: It's . . . it's the Jewish girl in the bathrobe!

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AMY: **(Pg 72-74)** The TV! It only feeds my mother's already obsessive concern over my safety.

AMY'S MOM: *(BEEP)* Yeah, hello, Amila. They just said on TV, "It's ten p.m., do you know where your children are? And I'm thinking, I don't know, so I figured I'd call you, ***mamascheinz***. You must be in the bathroom or something. Give me a buzz when you're don, okay? All right, bye-bye. *(Amy, sleeping soundly, snores)(BEEP)* Amila? It's five to eleven and I know you have work tomorrow. I'm getting ga little worried. Call me when you get the message.

AMY: This message was followed by FOUR separate messages from my friends, Michael, Sherry, Alison and Leslie, each saying that my mother had called them looking for me!

ANDREW: *(BEEP)* Hi, Amy. Yeah, it's Andrew. I just got a call from your mom about ten minutes ago, and she

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wanted to know if you were spending the night at my house. I told her we broke up four years ago.

HOSPITAL WORKER: *(BEEP)* Hello, Miss Borkowsky? I'm calling from NYU Hospital. Someone called here claiming to be your mother and wanting to know if you'd been admitted.

AMY: So where was I, you ask? In my own bed. Sound asleep. I'd conked out early and had just turned my ringer off. When I work up the next morning, I was sooooo mad. I could only imagine who she would have called next . . . *(Ring Ring)*

DAIRY BOARD: Good morning, National Dairy Board.

AMY'S MOM: Uh, yes, I'd like to find out how I can get my child's picture on a milk carton.

DAIRY BOARD: How long has the child been missing?

AMY'S MOM: A very long time. I'd say well over ninety minutes.

DAIRY BOARD: Okay, Ma'am, is this a boy or a girl?

AMY'S MOM: It's a girl – my Amila.

DAIRY BOARD: And what was she wearing when she disappeared?

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AMY'S MOM: Let's see . . . she probably had on a silk blouse with maybe a dark blazer, a matching skirt, and a pair of pumps.

DAIRY BOARD: Was she playing dress up?

AMY'S MOM: No. But she mentioned today she had to go see a new client.

DAIRY BOARD: Ma'am, how old is your Amila?

AMY'S MOM: Thirty-four and three quarters

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AMY: **(Pg 97-98)** People are always debating whether it's harmful for kids to watch too much TV, but I think the bigger problem is what happens when **your parents** watch too much TV!

AMY'S MOM: *(BEEP)* Amila? I just talked to you. Where'd you go? Anyway, I was watching the news and they had a story about the Hell's Angels motorcycle club. They flashed a shot of a big bear of a guy from Greenwich Village who was covered in tattoos, and on the back of his motorcycle was a very pretty girl. Was that you? She had your hair, and she was wearing a green blouse that looked like the one that I gave you for Chanuka. You know how I feel about motorcycles!

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AMY: *(Sarcastically)* I did understand her confusion. There are so few women in Manhattan with brown, wavy hair that, really, who wouldn't assume it was me? I'm constantly getting comments . . .

WOMAN: Excuse me, but I was just noticing how completely unique your hair is. What color would you call that?

AMY: Brown.

WOMAN: Can you write that down? I want to ask my colorist about it.

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AMY: **(Pg 8)** I love my mother, but . . . I know my mother means well, but . . . **(Pg 84)** Halloween . . . REALLY? I outgrew Halloween when I was around twelve!

AMY'S MOM: *(BEEP) (in her best scary voice)* Boooooo, Amila. Boooooooo. Okay, don't get scared. It's just me, honey. Tomorrow's Halloween, and I just want to warn you to throw out anything that looks suspicious in your trick-or-treat bag. Like if you should happen to find a hole in a candy bar, it could mean that someone stuck it with a hypodermic needle, all right? Happy Halloween!

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AMY: How could she even imagine me trick-or-treating at this age**?**

AMY'S MOM: **(Pg 74)** Thirty-four and three quarters **(Pg 84-85)** *(Knock, knock, knock)*

WOMAN 2: Who's there?

AMY: Trick or treat!

WOMAN 2: My goodness! What a wonderful costume! Can you wait just a minute?

AMY: Actually, I'm not wearing a cos . .

WOMAN 2: Staaaaanley! Bring the camera! There's a little girl dressed as Jerry's friend Elaine! She has the hair and everything! It's amazing. She even looks like she's in her thirties!

AMY: That's because . . .

WOMAN: Your mommy must've spent quite some time making your costume!

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AMY: **(Pg 11)** So . . . If your own mother drives you crazy, I hope you now know . . . You are not alone!

AMY'S MOM: *(BEEP)* **(Pg 26)** Amila . . . it's me again!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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